

Dear Jen,

Sometimes things just happen out of the blue. Things happen so suddenly that you cannot keep up with everything. Sometimes it just takes a while for you to be able to comprehend things. It's really funny you know how a thing can happen so quickly and yet take so much time to be comprehended. Today was one of those days. Today was a normal day. There was not much going on, and I was coordinating the Traffic Control Points for the night when I got a call from "Thunder 13."

It was somewhat odd because the voice on the other end of the transmission sounded hurried and somewhat frantic, "Thunderbolt X-Ray, Thunderbolt X-Ray this is Thunder 13." It was Lt. Williams, our physician's assistant. At first I was taken aback because he was so loud and so brash, not a common occurrence on the net these days. I responded calmly. I remember thinking that he simply must not have a lot of experience on the radio or something, and that was why he sounded so rude and upset. I didn't have to wonder for long. After I responded to him, the radio immediately crackled to life again, "Thunderbolt X-Ray this is Thunder 13, I have Thunderbolt 2 November with me and we have been hit. There are casualties." The words rang in my ears for a second and I tried to figure out what was really going on.

"This is Thunderbolt X-Ray," I responded, "Are you in contact?"

"Negative, we are not in contact," the PA crackled, "there has been an explosion and we need medical assistance."

"Roger," I managed to stay surprisingly calm and under control, "what is your location?"

"We are approximately four clicks west of the TOC location, in an alley."

"Do you know your grid location?"

"No, I don't have my plugger on me," he said, "but there should be an Avalanche checkpoint approximately 200 meters to our east."

"Roger," I responded, "help is on the way."

This short conversation at 7:50 has shaped every event from then on, and will shape many events in the future for many people. By the time I had completed my short interaction with Lt. Williams the TOC was buzzing with activity. Major Wick and Major Cribb were already standing around and Colonel Ingram was coming in through the door, almost jogging. Someone, I don't know who, had already run down and alerted the medics. For a short time, things began to move in slow motion. Everyone just seemed to

be staring at each other, and I don't if how accurate my account of the events will be from here. The next thing I remember is the sound of the radio coming to life again:

"Thunderbolt X-Ray this is Thunderbolt 13, I need assistance now. We have two US WIA and two Iraqi WIA. We have one DOA, and I am also wounded. I need help and I have to get back to treating these patients."

"This is Thunderbolt X-Ray," I answered, "help is on the way."

At some point, our Supply Officer, Captain Carey chimed into the conversation but was quickly cut off. The last thing we needed was another voice to complicate matters. Somehow, I think after several attempts to state his case, he managed to relay that he found the site where our personnel were injured. His HMMWV was sitting in the road as an easy reference point for the rest of the rescue team.

OK, things were progressing but I was oblivious to time. All I wanted to do was help and not get in the way. I handled several radio transmissions and ran several small coordination missions around our TOC area. I was informing this person of that, and getting that person to do this etc. I was curious as to who was hit and how it happened. There were so few details and so many questions. Who? What? How?

I'm not sure when the Colonel and the Sergeant Major went flying out of the room and off to find the scene for themselves, but they were gone in a flash. This left only the usual TOC personnel and the two Majors to manage the events from here. Major Wick, of course, immediately began to control everything. He took over the radios and the map. I moved to the back of the room and talked to different people as they walked in, informed them of the situation and what role they were expected to play. I gave different people different levels of information depending on their job and rank.

Soon after the Colonel left, his voice echoed through the loudspeaker on our radio, "This is 6, I am at the site now."

"Roger," was the simple reply.

We still knew nothing. No details, only the fact that there had been an accident. I would find out soon enough. I think this is when things started moving quickly again. The world, which had been in slow motion for some time, suddenly sped up to an accelerated pace. The Colonel's voice again snapped through the radio:

"X-Ray, 6. Three soldiers are being evac'd by Bounty. Lt. Collins, SSG Aldridge, and Lt. Williams. There is one KIA, and he is also being evacuated to the 203rd FSB."

It was real. Names and faces. I know them all, and have spent a lot of time with each of them. The only question that remained to be answered was who was killed, but I already knew. I don't know how, but I knew from the minute the I first talked to Lt. Williams. He had mentioned needing help and that he was with Thunderbolt 2 November, and then

he had not mentioned 2 November again. It had to be him, Master Sergeant Payne. I have spent a lot of time with the old Master Sergeant since we came to Iraq, and he was the Tank Commander for our APC all the way from Baghdad to Kuwait. I remember sitting on the back ramp of the 577 and him telling stories about what he would do when we got home and he retired. He would counsel Lt. Collins and myself on how to be young officers in the Army. He was our mentor over here; like a father in battle. Collins and I would ride in the back of the track, monitor radios and track movements on the map while Sergeant Payne would ride on top with his machine gun and direct our movements through the intercom built into his headset. I knew it was him, and it was. Killed in action—after the war was over. Had he made it, he would have retired when we got home with twenty some years in service. Dead.

Lt. Collins too, has become one of my best friends over here. He and I shared the same fate as TOC bitches. We have lived in the same room or vehicle nearly the entire time we have been over here. He is funny, and we loved to joke about getting out of here. "It wouldn't be too bad to run over a land mine and break a leg if it means we get to go home," we often said. Well, now he will find out. After the fact, I learned that the doctors had been concerned about his survival as well, but he pulled through. He is out of surgery now and on his way home soon I am sure. Yes, we are definitely friends and I am sad to hear that he was injured. Hey, look on the bright side, we found out to day that we have no idea when we will be headed home, but Collins should be on his way back to Riley very shortly. An interesting trade-off assuming that he is fully recovered.

Several hours later, the scout section that escorted the casualties to the 203rd FSB returned and brought with them a bag filled with Lt. Collins' stuff. I volunteered to take responsibility for his things. They gave me an inventory list that included only Army items such as BDU Top, Kevlar, 4 fully loaded Magazines and a pair of combat boots. I opened the plastic trash bag that was labeled "Collins," and made sure everything was there. It was dark outside as I reached down into the bag to find each item. When I reached in for the first time hoping to find the four loaded magazines, I found myself grasping in a puddle of liquid. When I pulled my hand out to look, I noticed that my hand was soaked in blood. I pulled out his DCU Top and pants and they were both saturated with red blood—still wet and warm. His boots too were red with blood, and his clothes had been cut off of him. I signed for it and moved his stuff up to our room and placed it on his bunk. That was that. I returned to the TOC and began to make sure that our different companies were preparing for their nighttime patrols and setting up their traffic control points. The mission does not stop.

The last five and a half hours have been very crazy. It is almost two a.m. now, and I am about to get off shift and go to bed. Lt. Collins is at Charlie-Med, recovering from his injuries. Master Sergeant Payne is dead. Its funny how things happen sometimes, and how some things just take some time to set in. I would be lying if I told you that I can fully comprehend what happened or that the reality of it has even sunk in at all. I don't know if I am sad, but I am definitely bewildered. Maybe I am just evil because I don't know if I will really be sad about it all. I feel bad for Sgt. Payne, but something keeps telling me that I didn't really know him that long and that I shouldn't be upset. I keep

plugging on. Lt. Collins will be ok, and I am happy that he will get to go home, but I know that I will miss him around here. Selfish? Perhaps. It has been a crazy day and I don't know what to think or how to feel exactly. Hopefully time will help me sort it out. I mean, its not like I have been through a traumatic experience. All I did was manage the radios and run little errands to help out. I don't feel that I have the right to be upset since nothing happened to me.

Rest assured, baby, I am fine and still carrying on. I wish we had a date when we will be coming home and I want to see you and Mason more than ever. I will end this letter the same way an eighth grade girl ended her letter to us.

TTFN (ta-ta-for-now)

Christian